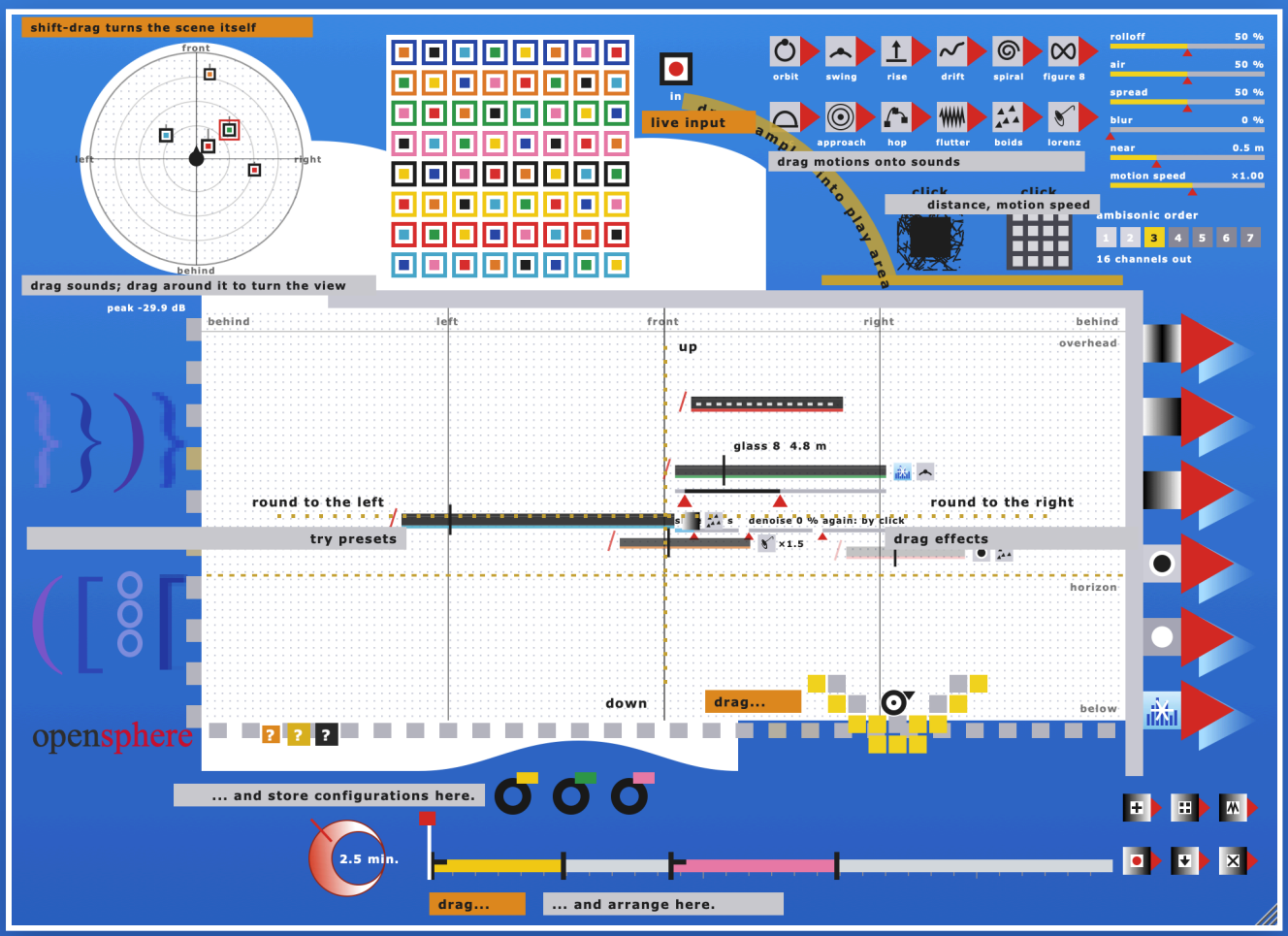
opensphere

manual · version 1.2

an ambisonics encoder



vst3 · vst2 · au · lv2 · standalone · macos · windows · linux

november 2026

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1 about opensphere

opensphere is a loop workspace that places its sounds in a sphere around you. You drag sounds into a window, they loop, and you keep moving and changing them while they play. The output is Ambisonics, so the result can be decoded to any speaker ring or dome, or to headphones.

It is the twin of **openprocess**, a loop workspace modelled on **ovalprocess** (2000) by Markus Popp, who records as Oval. Both are built from the same source code. Everything openprocess does, opensphere does the same way: the browser with 64 loops, effects, presets, logical operators, snapshots, the timeline, your own sounds, rendering, MIDI. What changes is the play area and the output.

	openprocess	opensphere
play area left ↔ right	stereo panorama	direction, once round you
play area top ↔ bottom	loud ↔ soft	height, overhead ↔ 45° below
level	by height in the play area	by distance (the globe)
movement	you move the sounds	also twelve motions; scene turn and tilt
audio input	capture and Input Thru	capture, and a live input placed in the space
output	stereo	Ambisonics, 1st – 7th order (4 – 64 channels)

why loops in space

Oval's music is made of short loops that drift against each other and never fall into a common beat. In stereo they share two speakers and blur together. Spread round a listener, each loop keeps its own place: you can hear which fragment is where, follow one while the others go on, and turn your head to bring another forward. A loop that orbits or rises slowly changes the piece without any change to the sound itself.

2 installing and setting up

opensphere comes in the **poppsphere bundle** (with openprocess and Quell): one download per system from the releases page of `github.com/femifleming/poppsphere-bundle`. On a Mac, Homebrew does it in one line: `brew install --cask femifleming/tap/opensphere`.

system	put the files here
macOS	`opensphere.vst3` → `~/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3`, `opensphere.component` → `…/Components`, `opensphere.vst` → `…/VST`, `opensphere.app` → `/Applications`. Universal: Apple silicon and Intel.
Windows	`opensphere.vst3` → `C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3`, `opensphere.dll` (VST2) → your VST folder; `opensphere.exe` runs on its own.
Linux	`opensphere.vst3` → `~/.vst3`, `opensphere.lv2` → `~/.lv2`, `opensphere.so` (VST2) → `~/.vst`; `opensphere` runs on its own (ALSA or JACK).

The macOS builds are signed ad hoc, not notarised. The Homebrew cask clears the quarantine flag; if you install by hand, right-click the app → Open the first time.

in a daw

opensphere needs a track with enough channels for the order you want: **4** for 1st order, **16** for 3rd, **36** for 5th, **64** for 7th (chapter 10). After it on the same track goes an Ambisonics **decoder**, which turns the channels into speaker feeds or binaural stereo for headphones.

1. Make a track and give it the channels. In **REAPER**: the track's *Routing* button → *Track channels* 16 (or 36, 64). The master track needs only 2 if the decoder is binaural.
2. Insert opensphere (VST3, VST2 or LV2). It offers up to 64 outputs and uses as many as the track has.
3. Insert a decoder after it, set to the same order and to **AmbiX (ACN / SN3D)**: for headphones IEM *BinauralDecoder* or SPARTA *AmbiBIN*; for speakers IEM *AllRADecoder* or SPARTA *AmbiDEC*.
4. Click a bracket on the left of opensphere. Something plays around you.

opensphere plays as soon as something is in the play area, whether or not the transport runs. It has nothing to do with the song tempo. Hosts that pass audio into the track feed the live input (chapter 9).

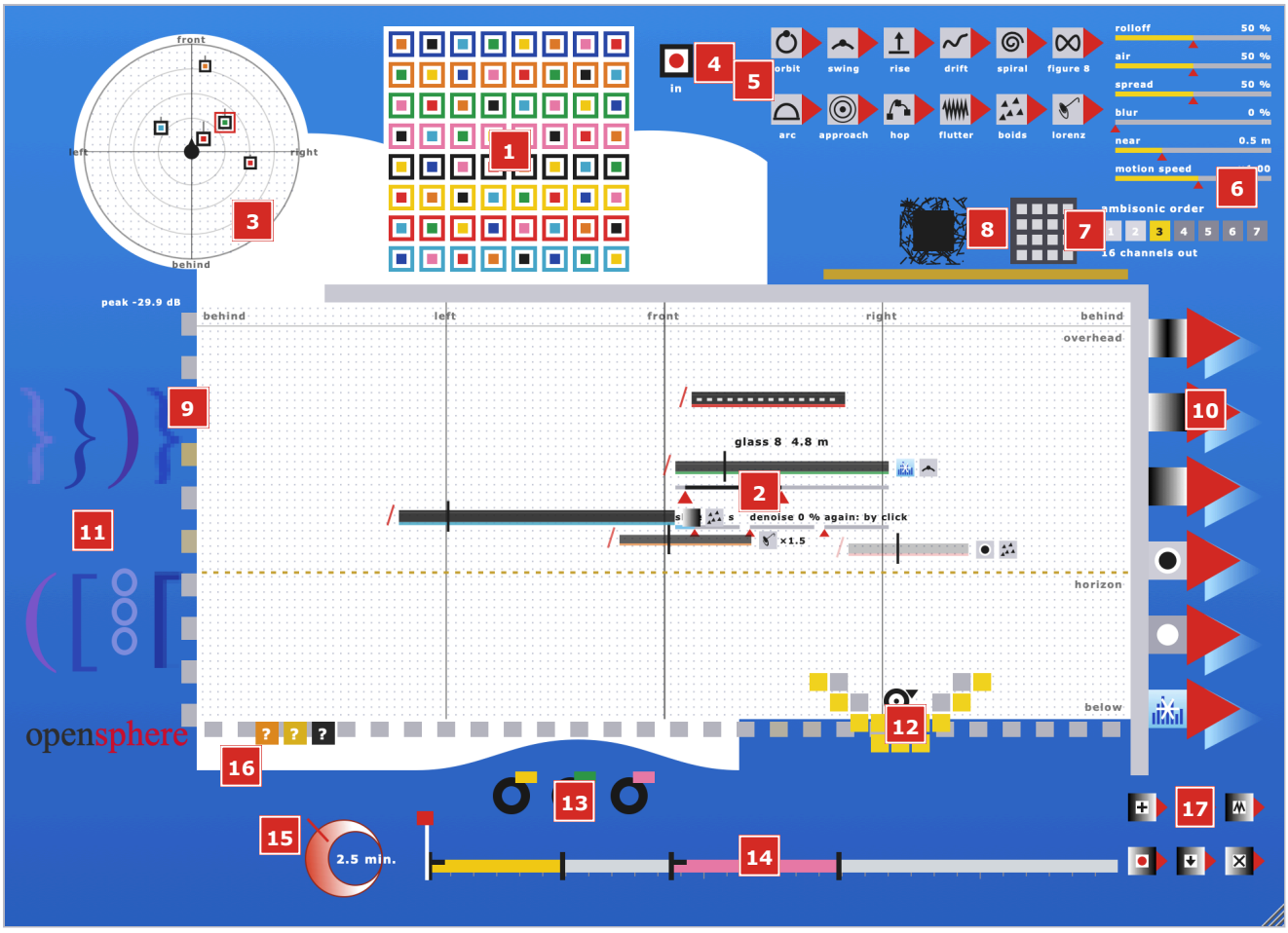
> **Ableton Live and Logic** have no tracks wide enough for this. There opensphere sees a stereo bus and plays a **stereo preview** (chapter 10). Build the piece with the preview and use *render to file* to write the full AmbiX file, which any Ambisonics player or decoder can then open. The **AU** version offers up to 3rd order (16 channels).

the standalone app

The app plays the stereo preview on the audio device set under *Options* → *Audio/MIDI Settings*; its renders are full AmbiX files at the chosen order. It asks for microphone access the first time, for capture and the live input. Your work is saved when you quit and is back when you start again.

The window can be resized from its lower right corner, from 600 to 1600 pixels wide. The proportions stay fixed.

3 the screen



1 browser: 8 × 8 loops

2 play area: the sphere around you, unrolled

3 globe: direction, distance, view and scene turn

4 live input (red **in** square)

5 motions: twelve, in two rows

6 distance settings and motion speed (rails)

7 ambisonic order and channels out

8 logical operators

9 spatial meter (the frame's squares)

10 effects

11 presets

12 snapshot button

13 snapshots (reels)

14 timeline with play flag

15 composition length wheel

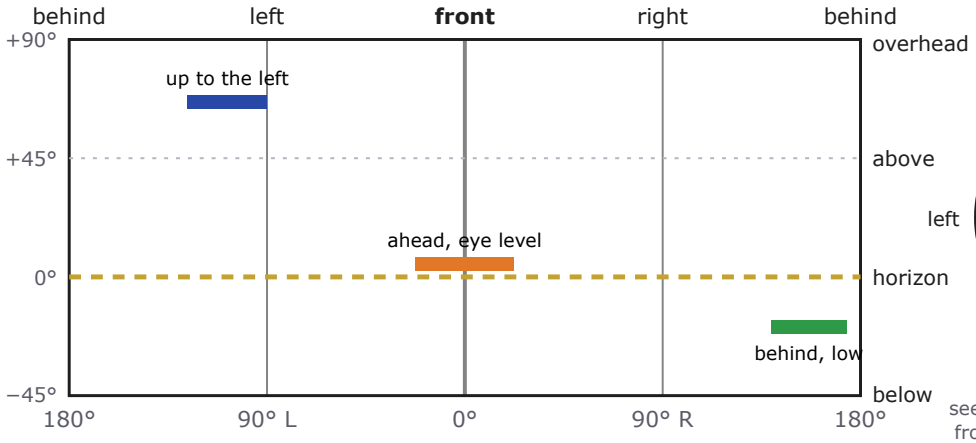
16 help marks · demo (word mark)

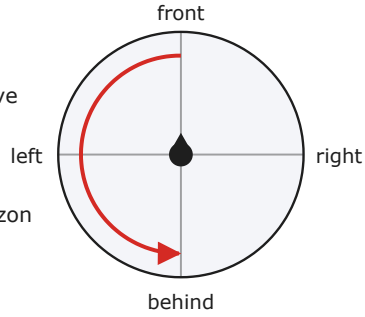
17 tools

In the picture, loops from the browser and the live input (the bar with white dashes) are playing. Sounds with a motion carry its small icon after their bar, with their own speed beside it when it isn't ×1. The selected sound shows its name, its distance in metres and the red pointers of its loop. Messages such as "the play area is full" appear for a few seconds in a grey tag at the top left.

4 the space

The play area is the sphere around you, cut open behind you and laid flat, like a map of the world. Where a sound sits in it is the direction it comes from.





seen from above: the play area from its middle to its left edge

left ↔ right: direction

The width of the play area is **once round you**. The middle line is straight **in front**. The quarter lines are **left** and **right**. Both edges are straight **behind**: they are the same place, where the sphere was cut. A sound that moves past one edge by itself (chapter 8) comes back in at the other.

The left half of the area is your left side, so the layout reads as if you faced the screen and the picture were wrapped round you.

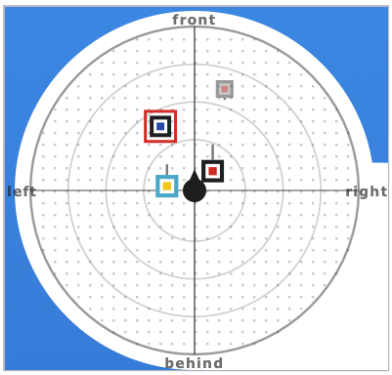
top ↔ bottom: height

The height runs from **45° below** (bottom edge) to straight **overhead** (top). The dotted mustard line is the **horizon**, ear level, one third of the way up. Most of the area is above you, where a dome of speakers is; the lower part reaches below for spheres and headphones.

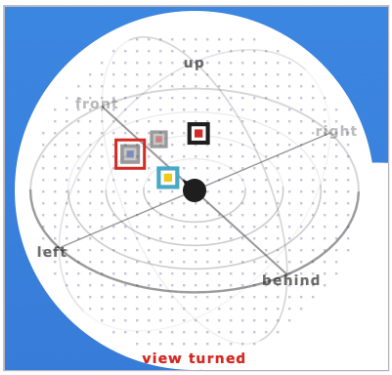
Near the top, directions close up: overhead every sound comes from the same point, whatever its left–right place. The height no longer changes the level, as it did in openprocess. Level comes from distance.

Sounds in the play area are drawn thick and solid when they are near and thin and faint when they are far away. Everything else about them works as in openprocess: drag to move, click to select, drag out to throw away.

5 the globe



seen from above (the default)



the view turned

The globe at the top left is the space with you in the middle, the black head. Four rings on the horizon mark a quarter, half, three quarters and the whole of the distance range; two circles run through overhead. Every sound appears as a small square in its browser colours. Squares on the far side are faint.

seen from above

At first the globe is seen from above, front at the top. The angle from you is a sound's direction (its left–right place in the play area), the distance from you its distance. A short stalk up or down shows that it is above or below the horizon. **Drag a square** to set direction and distance at once; its height stays.

turning the view

Drag the empty globe to turn it: sideways round the vertical, up and down to tip it, as far as a view from the side. Only the picture turns, nothing you hear. A red **view turned** shows below it. Now **dragging a square** moves the sound over its own shell: same distance, new direction and height, on the side facing you. The view can be turned while the timeline plays.

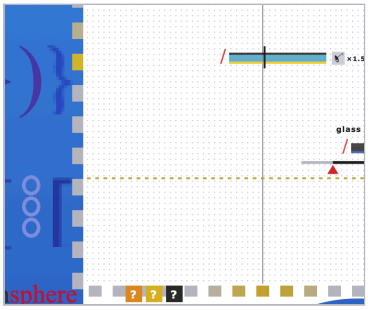
turning the scene

Shift-drag the empty globe to turn the sound scene itself: everything you hear turns round you (**Scene Turn**, −180° to 180°) and tips forward or back (**Scene Tilt**, −90° to 90°). The play area and the globe keep showing the sounds where you put them; the head turns to show where the front of the scene now is, and a red note gives **scene x° / y°**. Both are parameters, so a host can automate them.

Double-click the empty globe to see it from above again; **shift-double-click** also sets the scene turn and tilt back to 0.

Mouse wheel over a sound, on the globe or in the play area: up or away brings it nearer, down sends it further. The selected sound shows its distance in metres above its bar.

6 spatial meter



The grey squares of the frame round the play area are a meter of where the sound is. The **row of 28** under the play area shows level by **direction**, with the same left–right layout as the play area: behind, left, front, right, behind. The **column of 10** on its left shows level by **height**, from below at the bottom to overhead at the top.

Colours: **grey** below −36 dB, **mustard** to −24 dB, **yellow** to −14 dB, **orange** to −6 dB, **red** above.

The squares rise at once and fall by about 36 dB a second. Above the column, **peak −xx dB** gives the loudest square. The meter includes the Master level.

7 distance

what distance changes

Distance runs from 0 (at your head) to 1 (the outer ring), shown as **0.25 + 19.75 · d²** metres: 25 cm to 20 m. A new sound starts at about 2 m. With the distance settings at their defaults (below):

- **level**: 0 dB at your head, about −6 dB at 3 m, about −29 dB at the far edge.
- **width**: the two channels of a stereo loop are encoded as two points either side of its direction, 80° apart when near, 10° when far.
- **brightness**: a low-pass filter, the air, closes from 18 kHz near you to 3.5 kHz at the far edge.
- **near field**: within 0.12 (about half a metre) the higher orders fade out, so the sound loses its direction and surrounds you.

distance	metres	level	width	air	direction
0	0.25	0 dB	80°	18 kHz	none, all round you
0.12	0.53	−1.7 dB	72°	17.6 kHz	full from here on
0.3	2.03	−4.6 dB	59°	15.5 kHz	a new sound
0.5	5.19	−8.7 dB	45°	12 kHz	
1	20	−28.8 dB	10°	3.5 kHz	the outer ring

Gains glide over about 20 ms. Distance is not a delay: no Doppler, no room echo.

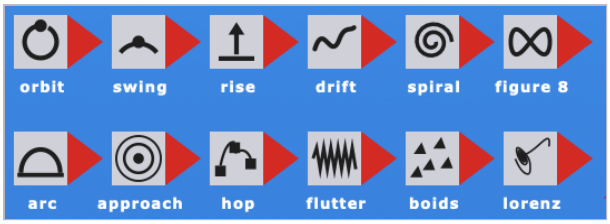
distance settings



The six rails at the top right shape what distance does, for all sounds at once, and set the speed of all motions. **Drag** along a rail to set it; **double-click** it for the default. All six are parameters a host can automate, and every snapshot stores them (chapter 14). While the timeline plays, the rails show the values of the segment that is playing.

rail	what it does	default
rolloff	how fast the level falls with distance. 50 % is the table above. At 0 % the far edge is only about 6 dB down; at 100 % a sound is 18 dB down at 5 m and practically silent (about −60 dB) from 11 m on.	50 %
air	how much top far sounds lose. 0 %: none. 50 %: 3.5 kHz at the far edge. 100 %: about 700 Hz.	50 %
spread	how wide a stereo sound is when near: 20° at 0 %, 80° at 50 %, 140° at 100 %. At the far edge every sound is 10° wide.	50 %
blur	how much far sounds lose the sharpness of their direction. The higher orders are turned down with distance, each order step to as little as 15 % at the far edge with blur at 100 %, so a far sound becomes broad and vague, like a 1st-order image.	0 %
near	the near-field radius: inside it the higher orders fade and the sound surrounds you, inside your head at 0. From 0 to 0.4 of the range, shown in metres (0.25 – 3.4 m).	0.5 m
motion speed	all motions faster or slower, ×0.1 to ×4, on top of each sound's own speed. It runs the motion clock, so changing it never makes a sound jump.	×1.00

8 motions



The twelve icons on red pointers at the top right are **motions**. **Drag one onto a sound** and it sticks as a small icon after the bar. From then on the sound moves through the space by itself. One motion and one effect per sound.

motion	what the sound does	period at ×1
orbit	goes once all the way round you; height and distance stay	24 s a turn
swing	swings to either side of its place, ±40°, like a pendulum	8 s
rise	rises from its height to straight overhead and sinks back	16 s
drift	wanders slowly round its place, sideways and up and down, never quite repeating	slow
spiral	goes round you while climbing towards overhead and coming back down	20 s a turn, 40 s up and down
figure 8	draws a figure of eight about its place, about ±43° sideways and ±11° up and down	10 s
arc	rises over your head, comes down on the opposite side, and goes back the same way	14 s there and back
approach	comes up close to you (to a tenth of its distance) and goes back out	12 s
hop	jumps to a new place near its own (up to about ±54° sideways, ±20° in height), with a short glide	every 3 s
flutter	trembles quickly by a few degrees, sideways, up and down and in distance, like wings	4 – 10 times a second
boids	all sounds with boids form **one flock**: they keep together, keep a little apart, fly the same way, are pulled back towards their own places and wander a little. Simulated as it plays, in renders too.	free
lorenz	follows its own stretch of the Lorenz attractor: the two wings swing it left and right, the other axes change its height and distance. A quarter of Lorenz time per second.	about 3 s a wing, never repeating

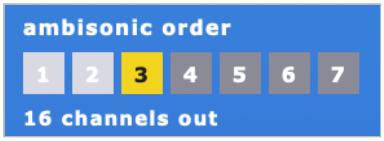
- **Each sound runs its own motion.** It starts when you drop it on, from where the sound is, so nothing jumps. Each copy has its own direction and slight differences of rate and path, so two sounds never move as one.
- **Speed:** turn the mouse wheel over the small motion icon on a sound. The speed goes from ×0.25 to ×4 and is shown beside the icon (×1.5). Changing it does not make the sound jump. The *motion speed* rail (chapter 7) scales all motions on top.
- **To remove a motion**, drag its icon off the sound, or drop the same motion on it again; the sound stays where it is at that moment. Dropping the icon on another sound gives that sound a fresh copy. Drag a moving sound to move its resting place.
- Motions and speeds are stored in snapshots; each timeline segment restarts them at its start (chapter 15), and a render starts them from the beginning.

9 live input



The red square marked **in**, right of the browser, is the audio input of the plug-in (or the app's audio device). Its dot grows with the input level. **Drag it into the play area** and the input is placed in the space like a loop: a black bar with white dashes, whose red line shows the level. Move it, set its distance and give it a motion as with any sound. Of the effects only **mute** and **solo** act on it. It can be placed more than once. It is stored in snapshots and plays on the timeline, but a **render** has no input: record it as a loop first with *capture input* (chapter 17).

10 output and order



opensphere's output is **Ambisonics**: not speaker feeds but a description of the whole sound field, which a decoder turns into whatever you listen on. The format is **AmbiX**: channels in **ACN** order with **SN3D** normalisation, as used by the IEM and SPARTA plug-ins, YouTube and most players.

The seven squares at the top right choose the **order**. Click one. The chosen order is yellow; the orders actually being sent are light. Below it, "**N channels out**" tells what goes out, or "stereo preview".

order	channels	where
1st	4	all formats
2nd	9	all formats
3rd	16	all; default; AU max.
4th	25	VST3, VST2, LV2
5th	36	VST3, VST2, LV2
6th	49	VST3, VST2, LV2
7th	64	VST3, VST2, LV2

Channels = (order + 1)². Renders are possible at every order in every format, the app included.

which order

Higher orders place sounds more sharply but need more channels and more speakers to pay off. **3rd order** is a good default for headphones and small rings; 5th to 7th suit large domes.

If the track has fewer channels than the chosen order needs, opensphere sends the highest order that fits, and the label shows it: with 16 channels and 5th order chosen, 3rd order goes out.

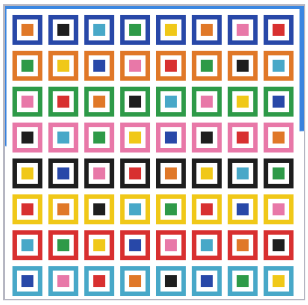
decoding

Put the decoder directly after opensphere on the same track. Set it to the same order and to ACN / SN3D: binaural for headphones, AllRAD or similar for speakers. A head-tracking rotator such as IEM *SceneRotator* goes between the two.

stereo preview

On a stereo track (Ableton Live, Logic) and in the standalone app, opensphere encodes at 1st order and folds it to left and right: **W + Y** and **W − Y**, two virtual microphones pointing left and right. You hear left and right, distance, width and motion, but not height, and front and back sound the same. Only the preview has a limiter: with many near sounds, keep *Master* down.

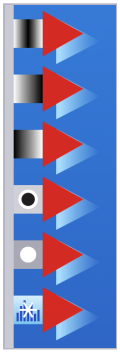
11 browser and loops



The browser holds 64 loops in an 8 × 8 grid. The outer colour of a square shows its **row**, the family of sounds; the inner colour tells the columns apart. **Drag a square into the play area** and the loop starts at that place, 2 m away. **Click a square** to select it for *skip again* and *capture input*. A pale square is still being made.

Click a sound in the play area to select it. Below it a grey strip stands for the whole sample, with **two red pointers**: the part between them loops. Loop ends are crossfaded over about 6 ms. Up to **24 sounds**, the live input included, can play at once.

12 effects



The six effects on the right edge work as in openprocess. **Drag one onto a sound**; it sticks as a small icon after the bar. One effect per sound; a new one replaces the old.

icon (top to bottom)	effect
black in the middle	**fade in / out** over each loop
white → black	**fade in** over each loop
black → white	**fade out** over each loop
black dot	**mute**: the sound keeps running, silently
white dot	**solo**: only sounds marked solo are heard
ice blue, white crystal	**freeze**: the sound becomes a held spectrum (after Jean-François Charles' freeze, as in ppooll's spectral freeze): its last 8 spectral frames are kept and every moment each frequency takes one of them at random, so it hangs in the air and shimmers

Freeze. A fraction of a second after it is dropped on, the sound freezes. **Click the icon** to freeze it again at that moment. When the sound is selected, three rails under its loop strip set **slide** (how slowly it glides into a new freeze, up to about 3 s), **denoise** (quiet frequencies drop out, leaving the strongest partials) and **again** (freeze again by itself every 0.5–20 s; at the left, only when you click). Frozen sounds are stored with these settings in snapshots. A freeze on a silent moment is silent: click again. The **matrix | scan** switch beside the rails picks the kind of freeze. **matrix** is the one above. **scan** (after Charles' freeze~) holds the last 1.4 s of frames instead and sweeps back and forth through them; the first rail then sets the **speed** (1x is as recorded, 0 holds a single frame, up to 2.8x).

To remove an effect, drag its icon off the sound or drop the same effect on it again. Dropping it on another sound moves it there.

13 presets and logical operators



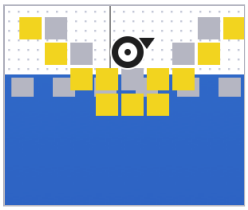
The eight brackets on the left are **presets**. A click fills the play area with 3 to 5 sounds, mostly from one browser row, never the same twice. Odd brackets use long parts of the samples (40–100 %), even brackets tiny fragments (3–25 %). **Shift-click** adds instead of replacing.

In opensphere, preset sounds are spread **all round you**, mostly a little above the horizon (from 15° below to 40° above), between half a metre and about 10 m away. Each has a one-in-four chance of a fade and about a one-in-three chance of one of the twelve motions.

The two **logical operators** above the play area change everything at once:

- **black scribble**: new loop lengths and start points for every sound, from 2 % to the whole sample.
- **grey grid**: a new place for every sound: any direction, from 30° below to 80° above, and a new distance. They glide there; motions and effects stay.

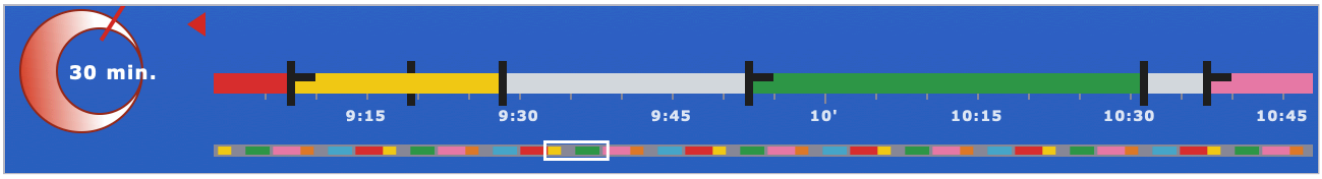
14 snapshots



Click the yellow chequered **snapshot button** at the bottom of the play area and the whole scene is stored: every sound (place, distance, loop, effect, motion and its speed), any live input, and the **global settings**: the six rails and the scene turn and tilt. The snapshot lines up below as a **reel**, a black ring with a colour tag. There is room for **10 reels**.

- **Drag a reel onto the timeline** to use it in a composition.
- **Drag a reel back into the play area** to hear that scene again. It replaces what is there and restores the rails and scene turn.
- **Throw a reel out of the window** to delete it.

15 timeline



Reels dropped on the timeline become **segments** in the reel's colour: 20 seconds long, or an eighth of the stretch on screen when you are zoomed out.

- **drag** a segment to move it, **drag its right end** to change its length
- **alt-drag** to copy it, **drag it away** (off the bar) to delete it

Overlapping segments play together. Each keeps its own copy of the snapshot and **plays with its own settings**: its motions restart at the segment's start, at its motion speed, with its distance settings and scene turn. So motion types, speeds, distance and scene turn can all be sequenced. Segments fade in and out over 30 ms. There is room for **256 segments**.

wheel

The red crescent sets the **length of the composition, from 1 to 30 minutes**: drag up or right for longer. The scale is logarithmic. Normally segments keep their places relative to the whole and stretch with it. **Shift-drag the wheel** and they keep their times in seconds instead; only the end moves (segments past a shorter end are dropped).

zoom

Thirty minutes do not fit on 540 pixels, so the timeline zooms. Over the timeline:

- **mouse wheel** up / away, or **pinch**: closer in, around the pointer
- **sideways scroll**, or **shift + wheel**: along the piece
- **double-click** the bare bar: 4× closer, or back to the whole piece

Zoomed in, a thin **overview strip** under the bar shows the whole piece with a white window round the part on screen; drag the window or click the strip to jump. Ticks are written as `9:30` or `10'`. You can zoom in until ten seconds fill the bar. Above: 30 minutes, zoomed in on 9–11 min.

play flag

The **red flag** is the play pointer. **Click it** to play from the flag to the end and round again, until you click again. **Drag it** to start later. Off screen, a red arrow shows where it is; while playing, the view pages along. **While it plays nothing else can be changed** (zoom still works); motions keep moving.

16 render to file

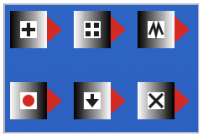
render to file (tools, ↓) writes the piece as an **AmbiX WAV**: 48 kHz, 24-bit, ACN / SN3D, with as many channels as the chosen order has, whatever the host or the app is playing. If the timeline has segments, the render runs from the play flag to the end of the composition; if not, it records the play area for the length set on the wheel. It is mixed at the current Master level.

The file is written as it goes, so a long piece needs no more memory than a short one; the corner counts up the percent. The default place is `~/Music/opensphere` (your Music folder on Windows and Linux too), with a name like `opensphere 2026-11-13 21.04.10.wav`. Files over 4 GB are written as **RF64**, the WAV variant without that limit; most audio editors and Ambisonics players read it.

order	channels	per minute	30 minutes
1st	4	35 MB	1.0 GB
3rd	16	138 MB	4.1 GB
5th	36	311 MB	9.3 GB
7th	64	553 MB	16.6 GB

The live input is not part of a render (chapter 9). Motions start from the beginning and the boids flock is simulated in the render, so the same piece renders the same way each time. A 30-minute piece at 3rd order is just under 4 GB, an ordinary WAV; at 4th order and above it becomes RF64.

17 sounds and tools



button	does
+ load sounds	choose files or folders to chop into the browser
▦ built-in sounds	restore the synthesized bank
^^ skip again	re-chop the selected square with a new pattern
• capture input	the last 8 s of input, silence trimmed, into the selected square; saved in `~/Music/opensphere/captures`
↓ render to file	write an AmbiX WAV (chapter 16)
× clear	empty the play area. **Shift-click**: clear everything (play area, reels and timeline) for a new piece

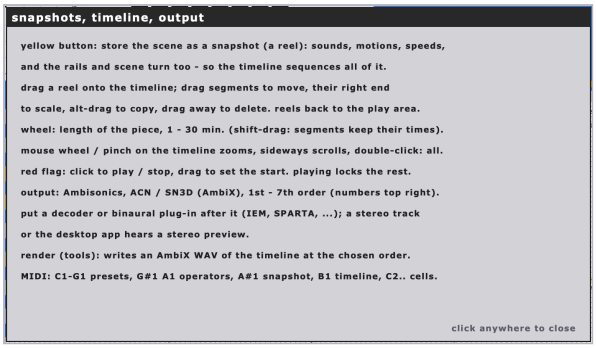
the built-in bank

All 64 loops are made by opensphere when it starts, the same bank as openprocess. Rows: **organ**, **guitar**, **feedback**, **skips**, **glass**, **low**, **noise**, **skipped**. All use the same pitches (D, E, F♯, A, B, C♯), so any can be combined. Loops are chopped like a skipping CD. **Columns run from clean on the left to heavily skipped on the right.** Loops are 0.5 to 9 seconds long and none is a multiple of another, so they drift against each other.

your own sounds

- **Drop audio files or folders onto the browser** (or use *load sounds*). Up to 256 files are chopped into all 64 squares.
- **Drop a single file onto one square** to replace only that square (first 30 seconds, unchopped).
- Formats: WAV, AIFF, FLAC, Ogg Vorbis, MP3, plus M4A/CAF on the Mac. A session remembers where its files are, not the audio.

18 help and demo



The three **?** marks next to the word mark open help without stopping the sound:

- **?** orange: the **guide**, the labels on the cover of this manual ("drag sounds; drag around it to turn the view", "shift-drag turns the scene itself", "drag motions onto sounds", "distance, motion speed", "live input" …). Click again to hide them.
- **?** yellow: **the space**: the play area, the globe, the mouse wheel, motions and their speed, rails, effects, the live input and the meter.
- **?** black: **snapshots, timeline, output** (above).

Click the word mark to start the **demo**. A cursor works through the functions on its own. **Any click ends the demo** and puts back exactly what you had. The standalone app starts it by itself after three minutes without input when the play area is empty.

19 midi and parameters

note	number	action
C1 – G1	36 – 43	presets 1 – 8
G♯1	44	operator: lengths
A1	45	operator: places
A♯1	46	snapshot
B1	47	timeline play / stop
C2 – D♯7	48 – 111	browser squares 1 – 64: add, or remove if playing

Middle C = C3. Notes act on note-on; velocity and note-off are ignored. While the timeline plays, only B1 has an effect. A square added by MIDI goes to a random direction, from 10° below to 40° above, 2 m away.

parameter	range	default
Master	0 – 1	0.8
Input Thru	0 – 1	0 (ignored)
Ambisonic Order	1st – 7th	3rd
Distance Rolloff	0 – 100 %	50 %
Distance Air	0 – 100 %	50 %
Near Spread	0 – 100 %	50 %
Distance Blur	0 – 100 %	0 %
Near Field	0 – 0.4	0.12
Motion Speed	×0.1 – ×4	×1
Scene Turn	−180° – 180°	0°
Scene Tilt	−90° – 90°	0°

All can be automated. **Master** scales everything that goes out and into renders. **Ambisonic Order** is the same as the seven squares. The next six are the rails (chapter 7), the last two the scene turn on the globe (chapter 5). **Input Thru** is kept so that sessions match openprocess, but opensphere ignores it: the input is heard only where you place it (chapter 9).

20 reference

item	value
browser	64 loops (8 rows × 8 columns), 0.5 – 9 s each
sounds in the play area	up to 24, live inputs included
direction	play area left → right: behind, left, front, right, behind (once round you)
height	play area bottom → top: −45° to +90°; horizon one third up
distance	0 – 1, shown as 0.25 – 20 m (0.25 + 19.75 · d²); new sounds 2 m
level by distance	rolloff 50 %: 0 dB at your head, −6 dB at about 3 m, −29 dB at 20 m
width of a stereo sound	near 20° – 140° (spread; 80° at 50 %) → 10° far
air	low-pass 18 kHz near → 3.5 kHz far at 50 % (700 Hz at 100 %)
blur	higher orders turned down with distance, to 15 % per order step at 100 %
near field	higher orders fade inside 0 – 0.4 (default 0.12, about 0.5 m)
scene rotation	turn −180° – 180°, tilt −90° – 90°; the globe view turns separately
motions	12: orbit 24 s · swing ±40°, 8 s · rise 16 s · drift · spiral 20 s / 40 s · figure 8 10 s · arc 14 s · approach 12 s · hop 3 s · flutter · boids (one flock) · lorenz; own speed ×0.25 – ×4, global ×0.1 – ×4
spatial meter	28 directions × 10 heights in the frame; −36 / −24 / −14 / −6 dB steps; falls 36 dB/s
output format	Ambisonics, ACN / SN3D (AmbiX), no Condon–Shortley phase
order	1st – 7th (4 – 64 channels), default 3rd; AU up to 3rd (16)
stereo preview	1st order folded to W + Y / W − Y; stereo buses and the standalone app
snapshots	up to 10; with motions, speeds, rails and scene turn
timeline segments	up to 256; new segments 20 s
composition length	1 – 30 minutes; the timeline zooms to 10 s
render	WAV, 48 kHz, 24-bit, AmbiX at the chosen order, streamed to disk, RF64 over 4 GB
user folder	`~/Music/opensphere`
saved with the session	play area (with distances, motions and speeds), snapshots, timeline, length, flag, how each square was made, parameters
plug-in code	`OpSp` (openprocess and opensphere can be used side by side)

Decoders that read opensphere directly: IEM Plug-in Suite (BinauralDecoder, AllRADecoder, SimpleDecoder, SceneRotator, up to 7th order) · SPARTA (AmbiBIN, AmbiDEC, Rotator) · any player or decoder that reads AmbiX (ACN / SN3D) files.

sources

Ovalprocess sound installation, Dokumentation, Bedienungs- und Wartungshinweise, and Markus Popp, ovalprocess project text (Berlin, 7 April 2001), Ars Electronica archive · Markus Popp, ovalprocess US 2k lecture v0.2, Ars Electronica archive · Oval, "Ovalprocess", *Leonardo* 35/5, 2002 · Sam Inglis, "Markus Popp: Music As Software", *Sound On Sound*, October 2002 · Marc Weidenbaum, interview with Markus Popp, Disquiet / Pulse!, 1996.

opensphere is an independent homage. It is not made, endorsed or distributed by Markus Popp or Oval.